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THE BAGHDAD-CANTON EXPRESS: ASIA ON FIVE DIRHEM A DAY

As the thirteenth century drew to a close, Genoa and Venice, the two great maritime powers of the Mediterranean Sea, savaged each other in a life-and-death struggle over trade routes. In a dank Genoese prison sometime around 1292, a Venetian naval commander whiled away the days and weeks dictating his memoirs to a fellow captive, a Pisan writer of modest renown named Rustichello.

And what a tale this prisoner, captured off the Dalmatian island of Curzola, had to tell his new friend! For at least a century before he was captured, his family had grown rich in trade with the East and maintained a warehouse filled with spices and silks in the Venetian quarter of Constantinople, the great trade hub of that era. Venice earned its wealth not only from rare Oriental goods, but also from the pilgrim and crusader traffic to and from the Holy Land.

Although the Venetian prisoner knew the East well, he was no pioneer. For centuries, European merchants, emissaries, and missionaries had ventured along the Silk Road in search of wealth, power, and converts. Indeed, about forty years previously, just after his birth, his father and uncle had struck out from their base in Constantinople and ventured deep into Mongol-ruled central Asia, where they eventually found themselves trapped by warring tribes in the trading town of Bukhara (in modern-day Uzbekistan). There they met an ambassador of Hulagu, the great khan of central Asia; fascinated by the brothers' Italian tongue, the khan's envoy invited them east. The two astute merchants did not need to be asked twice on an excursion to the lands of silk and spices.

By 1265 or so the brothers had arrived in the court of Hulagu's brother Kublai Khan in China, where they spent the better part of a decade before returning to Venice with a letter from Kublai to Pope Clement IV. The curious and ecumenical Kublai, it seems, needed a hundred Christian missionaries to teach the Chinese about this powerful Western faith. By the time the Venetians arrived home in 1269, however, Clement had died, and

the brothers, Maffeo and Niccolò Polo, had to bide their time until a new pontiff could supply them with the monks requested by Kublai. While they were away seeking their fortunes in China, Niccolò's wife had died, and he was left to care for his now fifteen-year-old son Marco, who had grown from a toddler to the brink of manhood.[1]

The original version of *The Travels of Marco Polo*, reconstructed by Rustichello from Marco Polo's recollections and notes requested from Venice, was probably first written down in French, then Europe's lingua franca, so to speak. The fantastical stories—of lands where cows were sacred, where widows threw themselves onto their husbands' funeral pyres, and where young men were abducted, drugged with hashish, plied with women and luxury, and trained as assassins (all of which occurred in India); of a place where the ground oozed with a gooey substance that burned (the oil fields of Mesopotamia); and of a place which was so far north that the sun never set in summer or rose in winter—struck Europeans as the product of a fevered imagination. The accuracy of *Travels* was, in fact, remarkable, including Polo's descriptions, passed to him at second and third hand, of places he did *not* visit, such as Burma, Siberia, Java, and the even more mysterious Spice Islands.

Although the family ran a well-known merchant house, and although *Travels* imparted a great deal about foreign mores, goods, dress, and customs, Marco Polo did not leave posterity many useful details about the texture of medieval long-distance trade. Perhaps the lack of quantitative data is the work of Rustichello, a seasoned writer who likely intuited that the medieval literary market responded better to self-immolating spouses and cities scores of miles in circumference than to pepper prices or to the precise patterns of monsoon sailing.[2]

Just as the stability afforded by the Pax Romana and the Han Empire encouraged the long-range and highly indirect commerce between Rome and China in the first and second centuries after Christ, the power of the early Islamic and Tang empires stimulated a far more direct intercourse between the lands of the caliphate and China during the seventh through ninth centuries. Chinese sources suggest that Islam arrived in Canton in about 620, a full dozen years *before* the death of the Prophet.[3]

Before the Chinese invented the magnetic compass, in around the twelfth century, mariners depended on celestial navigation; fog and overcast skies often proved as deadly as the fiercest storms. Although sailors since Greek times knew how to measure latitude, accurate determination of longitude did not become possible until the eighteenth century. The constant companion of the medieval traveler on the open seas was terror. As vividly recounted by a fifth century Chinese pilgrim who had voyaged to India and back:

> The Great Ocean spreads out over a boundless expanse. There is no knowing east from west; only by observing the sun, moon, and stars was it possible to go forward. If the weather was dark and rainy, the ship went forward as she was carried by the wind, without any definite course. In the darkness of the night, only the waves were to be seen, breaking on one another, emitting a brightness like that of fire.… The merchants were full of terror, not knowing where they were going. The sea was deep and bottomless, and there was no place where they could drop anchor.[4]

As early as the seventh century, the Chinese had seen enough Middle Eastern merchants to distinguish among the Muslims flooding into their ports: the “Po-ssi,” or Persians, with their long Gulf-based tradition of seafaring, were far more numerous than the more landlocked “Ta-shih,” or Arabs. The Chinese also clearly differentiated the world of Islam from a more mysterious land farther to the west called “Fu-lin”—the Byzantine Empire—known for its wondrous gemstones and glass.[5] By 758, there were enough Muslims in Canton that they were able to sack the city, burn it, and make off to sea with their booty.[6]

The Muslims, especially the Persians, knew China much better than the Chinese knew them. While the existence of pre-Islamic Persian trade with China is controversial, it is certain that not long after the Muslim armies defeated the Persian Sassanids at the battle of Ctesiphon (just south of modern Baghdad) in 636, Arab and Persian vessels voyaged directly to Chinese ports. As good a description as any of the Islamic world trade system under the caliphate is found in a Chinese document from 727:



The Po-ssi being by nature bent on commerce, they are in the habit of sailing in big craft on the [Mediterranean] sea, and they enter the Indian Ocean to Ceylon, where they get precious stones…. They also go to the K'un-lun country [probably Africa] to fetch gold. They also sail in big craft to China straight to Canton for silk piece goods and the like ware. The inhabitants enjoy the killing of cattle; they serve Heaven [Allah] and do not know the law of Buddha.[7]

The "Po-ssi" established trade diasporas all along the Chinese coast — large populations of Muslim merchants who handled an increasing volume of imports and exports. Jews accompanied them or followed in their footsteps. Nearly simultaneously, Nestorian Christians, expelled for their heresies from the Byzantine Empire but tolerated in the Muslim world as "people of the book," began to arrive from the West via the overland route. It is easy to see how a splinter Christian movement, repelled by the savage intolerance of the Catholic Church and attracted by the relative tolerance of Islam, spread ever eastward.

Contact between the East and West intensified with the triumph of the Abbasids over the Umayyads in 750; this moved the center of Islam from the landlocked capital of Damascus to riverine Baghdad, with its easy connection to the Gulf. One Abbasid ruler exclaimed, "This is the Tigris; there is no obstacle between us and China; everything on the sea can come to us on it."[8]

The premodern record provides few statistics regarding trade, and history's flashlight illuminates the commerce between China and the

Islamic world only with sporadic manuscript finds. One of the best-known manuscripts is the Arabic *Akhbar Al-Sin wa'l-Hind*—"An Account of China and India." Supposedly written in the mid-ninth century by several Arab merchants, particularly one Sulayman, this compilation takes the reader on a whirlwind journey from Baghdad to Canton, presaging the wonder and adventure evoked more than four hundred years later in *The Travels of Marco Polo.*

Akhbar describes the loading of the ships in Basra and at Siraf, a deepwater Persian Gulf port, followed by a monsoon-driven passage of one month from Oman, just outside Hormuz, to the Malabar coast of India, where the local ruler collected a tax of between ten and thirty dinars per vessel (approximately $800 to $2,400 in today's money). The Persian ships then set sail for another monthlong reach across the Bay of Bengal, provisioning midway in the Andaman Islands:

> The inhabitants are cannibals. They are black with curly hair, and have ugly faces and eyes and have long legs. Each one has a penis that is nearly a cubit [twenty inches] long; and they are naked…. Sometimes the cannibals catch some of the sailors, but they escape.[9]

The merchants made landfall in Southeast Asia on the coast of Kedah, just north of Penang in present-day Malaysia, where they could choose between proceeding south around the Strait of Malacca or portaging across the narrow waist of the Malay Peninsula. The journey from Kedah past Malacca to Indochina took about twenty days; from Indochina to Canton an additional month. Although *Akhbar* suggests that the entire voyage from Basra to Canton consumed only about four months' sailing time, the dance of the monsoons, as well as bureaucratic obstacles along the route, would have lengthened the transit time to well over a year.

Because merchants and captains preferred to ride the monsoons to and from their home port on an annual schedule, individual boats and crews tended to ply only one segment of the route year after year (if they were lucky enough to survive so many journeys). A Gujarati merchant, for example, would typically load his ship with the fine cotton cloths and indigo of his native land, sail the summer monsoon to Malacca, exchange there his goods for silk, spices, and porcelain, and return home on the winter monsoon. Or he might choose to sail west in the winter and return in the summer from Aden with horses and incense, or to Malindi on the East African coast and return with gold and slaves. Because of the pattern of the

monsoons and the need to return home, goods traveling the entire length of the Baghdad-Canton route sailed in at least three different bottoms.

The Chinese sought from *Akhbar's* Arab and Persian traders copper, ivory, incense, and turtle shells, while in Canton the Muslims loaded up on gold, pearls, and, naturally, silk and brocade. The exchange process was agonizing and appears to have been conducted through a government monopoly; the Chinese held the goods brought from Baghdad in Canton warehouses for six months until "the next batch of sailors come in." Thirty percent of the goods were taken as an import duty, and then, "Whatever the government wishes to take, [it] buys at the highest price and pays the amount immediately, and in the transaction do not act unjustly."[10]

Akhbar kicked off the venerable Western tradition of the China travelogue, later amplified by Marco Polo, Ibn Battuta, and numerous subsequent voyagers. The mostly anonymous authors of *Akhbar* wondered at the size and sophistication of the Celestial Empire, with its more than two hundred large cities, its exotic lifestyle, and its advanced institutions: "Everyone among the Chinese, whether he is poor or rich or young or old, learns calligraphy and the art of writing." Those concerned with the current debate over Social Security would do well to consider *Akhbar*'s description of the Chinese system of taxes and old-age pensions:

> [Tax] is collected per head on the basis of personal possession of wealth and land. If a son is born to anyone, his name is registered with the authority. When he reaches eighteen years of age, poll-tax is collected from him, and, when he reaches eighty years of age, no poll-tax is collected from him. He is then paid a [pension] from the treasury. They say, "We took from him when he was a youth, and we pay him a salary when he is old."[11]

Not all things Chinese pleased the sensibilities of pious Muslims. Particularly disagreeable were the diet high in pork and the use of toilet paper, both serious violations of Muslim sanitary rules. Finally, the Muslims made note of a most peculiar beverage:

> Among the important sources of revenue of the king is … an herb which they mix in hot water and then drink. It is sold in every town at a very high price. It is called *al-sakh.* It is more leafy than the green trefoil and slightly more perfumed, and has a soury taste. They boil water and then sprinkle the leaves over it. It is a cure for them for everything.[12]

The West had just encountered tea, a commodity that almost a thousand years later would spawn its own trading empire and multiply the world's

demand for sugar, slaves, and porcelain.

About a century after *Akhbar* was written, a Persian sea captain, Burzug Ibn Shahriyar, recorded 123 brief stories, which came to him first- or secondhand from sailors and traders. It was entitled *The Book of the Marvels of India* and featured unreal, fearsome beasts and man-eating giants worthy of a South American novelist; there was even an island of women who fell upon shipwrecked men:

> a thousand women or more to every one man, and carried them away towards the mountains and forced them to become the instruments of their pleasure…. One after the other, the men dropped off and died of sheer exhaustion."[13]

Strewn, however, throughout the fantastic narratives are vignettes illuminating the nature of medieval trade on the Indian Ocean. The book makes clear that the fear of shipwreck looms over both trader and sailor; almost every story involves at least one broken boat. The voyage to China is so fraught with peril that the story of a captain who made seven journeys there astonishes the author:

> Before his time, no one had ever accomplished this journey without accident. To reach China and not perish on the way—that, in itself, was regarded as a considerable feat; but come back again, safe and sound, was a thing unheard of.[14]

Only the promise of fantastic wealth could drive men to risk such nearly certain disaster. *Marvels* tells of a Jewish merchant, Ishaq, the owner of a ship that was

> laden with a million dinars of musk, as well as silks and porcelain of equal value, and quite as much again in jewelry and stones, not counting a whole heap of marvelous objects of Chinese workmanship.[15]

Marvels goes on to describe a gift given by Ishaq to a Muslim friend, a vase of black porcelain with a gold lid. When his friend asked what was in it, Ishaq replied, "A dish of *sekbadj* [fish] I cooked you in China." His friend replied that the delicacy, now two years old, must be quite spoiled. When he opened the vase, he found inside "a golden fish, with ruby eyes, garnished with musk of the finest quality. The contents of the vase was worth fifty thousand dinars." In the end, Ishaq is cheated out of his fortune by mendacious Muslim neighbors and then murdered by a Sudanese governor after failing to produce an expected bribe.[16]

The longest story in *Marvels* poignantly describes two other features of the medieval Indian Ocean trade: the unself-conscious, unscrupulous, highly profitable slave trade; and the power of Islam to tie together Chinese, Arabs, Persians, and Indians into a commercial system whose customs and laws were well understood by all between Baghdad and Canton.

The tale begins, as usual, with a shipwreck, this time on the shores of East Africa. Fearful of cannibals, the marooned traders are pleasantly surprised to be taken in and treated well by the local king, who even allows them to conduct their business: “and excellent business for us it was, with no restriction and no duties to pay.” After completing their trades, the ruler and his underlings accompany them onto their newly repaired vessels. As the merchants are about to depart, the narrator finds himself calculating his hosts’ value in the slave markets:

> That young king would fetch at least thirty dinars in the marketplace in Oman, and his attendants one hundred and sixty dinars the lot. Their clothes are worth twenty dinars at the lowest. Altogether, we should make a profit of not less than three thousand dirhems, without stirring a finger.[17]

Away they sail with their captives. The king attempts to shame the merchants by reminding them of the kind treatment received under his care, but his pleas fall on deaf ears. Along the way, over two hundred other slaves are added to the cargo hold; all, including the king and his retinue, are duly sold into slavery in Oman.

Years pass, and as luck would have it, the narrator finds himself once again shipwrecked on the exact same East African shore. Worse, he finds himself greeted by the very same king he had long ago sold into slavery. Staring directly into the eyes of the fearsome justice that is his due, the narrator is amazed when the king calmly and politely describes how his buyer in Oman took him to Basra and Baghdad, where the king-slave converted to Islam. Soon after arriving in Baghdad, he escaped, and after a series of hair-raising adventures in Cairo, on the Nile, and in the African bush, found himself back in his old kingdom, which had also converted to Islam in his absence.

Observing the commercial customs and laws of Islam rewarded the trading nation; both now dictated that the king treat the treacherous merchant well. As put by the king, “Musulmans shall know that they may come to us like brothers, since we are Musulmans too.” The king laments

that his fondest desire is to reimburse his old master in Baghdad for his loss, "a sum ten times what he paid, as recompense for the delay." Unfortunately, this wish must remain unfulfilled, since this is a job for an honest man—something the narrator clearly is not.[18]

This first flush of direct trade centering on China, so well described in *Akhbar* and *Marvels*, came crashing down as the Tang dynasty spiraled into instability in the ninth century. In a scenario painfully familiar to modern Chinese in Indonesia, Indians in East Africa, and Jews nearly everywhere, the colonies of foreign traders on China's coast became convenient scapegoats during tough times.

As early as AD 840, the emperor Wuzong sought to blame foreign ideologies for China's plight. In 878, the rebel Huang Chao sacked Canton, slaughtering 120,000 Muslims (mainly Persians), Jews, and Christians living in that city's trade community.[19] Not content to massacre traders, Huang Chao also tried to kill China's main export industry by destroying the mulberry groves of south China.[20] After the calamitous events of 878 in Canton, China's foreign trade gradually migrated north to the port of Tsuan-chou on the Taiwan Strait—the legendary Zaitun of Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta. Canton, which had been China's main portal for foreign goods, would not regain its preeminence until the modern period.

This more northerly entrepôt had long-standing connections with Korea and Japan, whose wares attracted Arab and Persian traders. The size and cargoes of the Muslim ships, some of which required ladders dozens of feet tall for boarding, astounded the Chinese of the eighth and ninth centuries. The emperor soon appointed an inspector of maritime trade, whose job was to register these vessels, collect duties, and prevent the export of "rare and precious articles."[21] One such inspector was a nobleman, Chau Ju-Kua, who oversaw foreign trade at Zaitun in the early thirteenth century. A methodical compiler of knowledge, he cataloged the recollections of hundreds of homesick sailors and traders in *Chu-Fan-Chi*: "A Description of Barbarous Peoples." The book was a sort of reverse *Travels of Marco Polo;* although Chau never left China, the *Chu-Fan-Chi* describes in some detail places as remote as Asia Minor and Alexandria, including details (some accurate, some not) of that city's famous lighthouse.[22]

By the time the Mongols roared out of the northern steppes into China in the thirteenth century, Persian and Arab traders had more or less

monopolized the long-distance trade in China, with two large and relatively self-governing Muslim communities at Canton and Zaitun. According to Chau:

> In its watchful kindness to the foreign Barbarians, our government has established at [Zaitun] and Canton Special Inspectorates of [maritime trade], and whenever any of the foreign traders have difficulties or wish to lay a complaint they must go to the Special Inspectorate.… Of all the wealthy foreign lands which have a great store of precious and varied goods, none surpasses the realm of the Arabs.[23]

Numerous other medieval travelers speak to us from differing perspectives. In the mid-twelfth century, a Spanish rabbi, Benjamin of Tudela, journeyed widely through Europe and the Middle East and reported on the bustle and splendors of Alexandria and Constantinople. He was particularly impressed by the intellectual life of Baghdad: "the place of meeting of philosophers, mathematicians, and all the other sciences." Almost at the same time, the Muslim merchant Shereef Idrisi, under the patronage of the Viking king of Sicily, Roger II, produced a geography, *Pleasure for the Man Who Wants to Know Thoroughly the Various Countries of the World*, which describes in great detail the Red Sea trade of the period. Idrisi was especially taken with the port of Aden, where he encountered Chinese junks laden with "pepper, some strong smelling, other odorless, wood of aloes, as well as bitter aloes, tortoise shell and ivory, ebony and rattan, porcelain, [and] leather saddles."[24]

The trading world of these accounts also found expression in a series of anonymous stories told by the fictional Scheherazade in her attempt to postpone her death at the hands of her husband: the famous *Book of the Thousand Nights and a Night.* Among its contents are the well-known tales of Ali Baba, Aladdin, and, of course, Sinbad the Sailor, which were probably recorded sometime in the fourteenth century.[25]

Sinbad's adventures were anything but children's stories. Many of them are remarkably similar to those told in *The Book of the Marvels of India;* the reader of both works will suspect that many of the Sinbad legends, if not lifted in whole cloth from the earlier book, at least share the same oral tradition.

In each of his seven trading voyages in search of spices and gems, our hero is shipwrecked or otherwise becomes separated from his ship. He then battles a series of deadly monsters or human villains. On his third trip, for

example, he and his companions are captured by a grotesque giant who first examines potential victims “as a butcher feeleth a sheep he is about to slaughter.” The gorgon finally settles on the ship’s most plump and delectable morsel, its *rais* (master). The gorgon

> seized him, as a butcher seizeth a beast, and throwing him down, set his foot on his neck and brake it; after which he fetched a long spit and thrusting up his backside, brought forth of the crown of his head. Then, lighting a fierce fire, he set it over the spit with the Rais thereon, and turned it over the coals, till the flesh was roasted, when he took the spit off the fire and set it like a Kabab-stick before him. Then he tare off the body, limb from limb, as one jointeth a chicken and, rending the flesh with his nails, fell to eating of it and gnawing the bones, till there was nothing left but some of these, which he threw on one side of the wall.[26]

All of Sinbad’s companions meet the same end except for our skinny hero, who is deemed an unworthy tidbit and released. In addition to his far-fetched escapades, the tales of Sinbad also provide a picture of the gritty day-to-day reality of long-distance commerce in the Abbasid and Fatimid periods. Even a cursory reading of *Nights* reveals that Sinbad was no sailor at all, but rather the scion of a wealthy Baghdad trading family that possessed many palaces and warehouses. Sinbad did not own, command, or, as far as we can tell, even crew on any of the vessels he sailed.

In fairness, a fine line separated the trader from the sailor on the Indian Ocean, as few crew members received a salary; rather, most of them made their living carrying trade goods on their own account.[27] Whatever Sinbad’s precise job description, he recounts the modus operandi of traders familiar to the reader of the Geniza papers:

> I bought me goods, merchandise all needed for a voyage and, impatient to be at sea, I embarked, with a company of merchants, on board a ship for Bassorah [modern Basra, at the head of the Persian Gulf]. There we again embarked and sailed many days and nights, and we passed from isle to isle and sea to sea and shore to shore, buying and selling and bartering everywhere the ship touched.[28]

As already discussed, the Red Sea challenged the merchant with pirates, narrow channels, dangerous shoals, and adverse winds, and the Silk Road suffered from the inherent physical inefficiencies and even greater dangers and political problems of a land route. Of the three great conduits between Asia and Europe, the remaining path—“Sinbad’s Way,” via the Mediterranean, across the Syrian desert, down the Tigris or Euphrates, and out the Persian Gulf into the Indian Ocean—was clearly the preferred route.

Each of Sinbad's expeditions begins with the laying in of goods from his Abbasid homeland to be exchanged abroad, in particular the fine textiles of Baghdad. From that city, Sinbad proceeded by small river craft downstream to Basra, thence onto a larger oceangoing vessel for the journey through the Persian Gulf and Indian Ocean.

In the course of his travails, he usually managed to lose and later regain his Baghdadi trade goods, then proceed to make "a great profit on them, and bought me goods and gear of the growth and fashion" to fill his family's warehouses back home. Soon after he avoided being a dinner course for the gorgon, Sinbad recounts:

> We ceased not to buy and sell at the several islands till we came to the land of Hind [India], where we bought cloves and ginger and all manner of spices; and thence we fared on to the land of Sind [China], where we also bought and sold…. Then we set sail again with a fair wind and the blessing of Almighty Allah; and after a prosperous voyage, arrived safe and sound in Bassorah. Here I abode a few days and presently returned to Baghdad where I went at once to my quarter and my house and saluted my family and familiars and friends.[29]

What drives this mythical hero? Nothing more and nothing less than a faithful medieval Islamic rendition of Adam Smith's propensity to truck and barter: a desire for "the society of the various races of mankind and for traffic and profit," to which has been added more than a dab of romance and adventure along the sea-lanes between Baghdad and Canton.[30]

Sinbad's mythical creatures—gigantic, ferocious birds who fed on jewel-encrusted carrion (identical to the beasts in *Marvels)*, fish so large that sailors mistook them for islands, and man-eating gorgons—merely reflected the limited geographical horizons of the premodern world. Europeans spun equally fabulous yarns about the East: the lands of Gog and Magog, of a breed of hairy kneeless humanoids whose blood yielded the precious red dye used in Chinese fabrics, and of a Far Eastern Christian empire ruled by Prester John. The Chinese spun equally wild tales of the West, such as water-dwelling sheep from which cotton was sheared.[31] These fictional and nonfictional accounts from the era of the medieval Indian Ocean trade, scattered and incomplete as they are, make clear that the four main luxury products of China—silk, sandalwood, spices, and porcelain—were somehow exchanged for what the East desired from Arabia and Africa: thoroughbred horses, ivory, incense, cottons, gold, and copper. Grain, as always, was shipped, particularly as ballast: rice, which in some cases

actually improves with age, was heavily favored over wheat, which is far more prone to spoilage.[32]

Since ancient times, the great civilizations of both East and West had been beset by bordering tribes of plundering herdsmen. Stretching in a broad band from northern Europe to Mongolia, and usually of Turkic origin in Asia or of Germano-Scandinavian origin in Europe, these nomadic raiders deployed skills honed over millennia of attacks on settled farmers. Periodically, they overwhelmed their more agriculturally proficient, institutionally advanced, and culturally accomplished sedentary neighbors, as occurred to Rome in the fifth century after Christ.

Their most spectacular success, however, occurred in the early thirteenth century, when Genghis Khan roared out of the steppes to conquer all of central Asia; within a few decades, the Great Khan's descendants ruled over a group of empires comprising more territory than any dynasty before or since.

In 1255, one of Genghis Khan's grandsons, Mongke, sent his brother Hulagu (whose ambassador had invited the Polo brothers east) to conquer the Muslim world. Hulagu destroyed Baghdad in 1258 and massacred hundreds of thousands in the process, a tragedy still mourned in the Muslim world today. The Mongols surely would have continued into the Mediterranean had not Mongke died at that moment, forcing Hulagu to return to Mongolia in an attempt to claim his dead brother's mantle. He left behind a rump force that fell prey to the Mamluk Egyptians in 1260 at Ain Jalut in Palestine. Adding insult to injury, Hulagu failed to grab Mongke's crown, which instead fell to a third brother, Kublai, who would subsequently wrest China from the Song dynasty.

For over a century, from the mid-1200s to the mid-1300s, the overland route from China to the gates of Europe lay in the hands of a more or less stable chain of Mongol states, which enthusiastically embraced commerce as well as the religions and cultures of the peoples they conquered. Three of Asia's four great Mongol empires eventually converted to Islam; the only one that did not, the legendary Kublai's Chinese dynasty, rapidly assimilated China's ancient culture. The Mongols adopted Islamic and Christian influences as well. Kublai, distrusting the preexisting Mandarin

bureaucracy, hired into his service many foreigners, whose numbers included all three Polos.

For about a century, beginning around 1260 after the conquests of Genghis's grandchildren and ending with the dissolution of Mongol dynasties from internal strife and the plague, the Silk Road lay unobstructed. Large numbers of Europeans and Muslims exploited this relatively brief opportunity and shuttled with ease between China and the West, but the names of two burn brightest in the light of history—Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta.

The Polos, a clan of consummate traders, exploited the window first, just as it was being opened up by Ghengis's grandchildren. Ibn Battuta, on the other hand, was not even a trader, but rather a *qadi*—a Muslim judge. Born into a scholarly family in Tangier, Morocco, in 1304, he studied Islamic law, as had generations of his male relatives. On completion of his studies he made the mandatory hajj to Mecca in 1325, one year after the death of Marco Polo.

The road must have appealed to him, for over the next three decades he journeyed approximately 74,000 miles throughout Asia, Africa, and Europe. A sort of medieval Islamic version of the modern Eurailpass-carrying flower child used to supplementing family money with guitar, harmonica, and donation box, he flogged his expertise in sharia (sacred law) for all it was worth and in the process acquired an ever-increasing amount of wealth, power, and female company. When boredom, adverse circumstances, or, on occasion, out-and-out self-preservation required him to, he moved on, not infrequently leaving behind a trail of discarded concubines and unhappy ex-wives, offspring, and in-laws.

Around 1300, a vigorous line of Turkic Muslims wrested northern and central India from its ancient Hindu dynasties and established their sultanate in Delhi. The most famous of these early Muslim masters of India was Sultan Muhammad Ibn Tughluq, who ruled from 1325 to 1351, a period roughly corresponding to the span of Battuta's epic journey. Tughluq became notorious for his hare-brained military, agricultural, and institutional schemes. These included an ill-fated attempt to move his capital four hundred miles south into the dusty, desolate Deccan plain of south India; a regimentation of Indian agriculture that ended in starvation and revolt; and the raising of a vast army to conquer the central Asian

Mongols. (He largely abandoned the last plan, except for a force sent to Kashmir that was destroyed by mountain tribes.)

But Tughluq's real passion was Islamic law. Shortly after taking power, he began to import eminent scholars from the Islamic world. He spared no expense, offering fabulous sinecures, accommodations, and privileges to the most attractive recruits. By this time, Battuta was traversing the Hindu Kush mountains of northwest India. On the road for approximately eight years and accustomed to traveling in style (which in that era meant a train of pack mules, luxurious portable furniture and tents, and a small army of slaves and women), he was on the brink of exhausting his family funds. When word reached him of the opportunities at the Delhi court, he heeded the call.

Along the way, Battuta passed through the lower Indus Valley, revered by Muslims as the first part of the subcontinent to receive Islam in the eighth century. While he was en route, Hindu bandits attacked his party. He casually noted:

> The inhabitants of India are in general infidels [Hindus]; some of them live under the protection of the Mohammedans, and reside either in the villages or cities: others, however, infest the mountains and rob by highways. I happened to be of a party of two and twenty men, when a number of Hindus, consisting of two horsemen and eighty foot, made an attack upon us. We, however, engaged them, and by God's help put them to flight, having killed one horseman and twelve of the foot.[33]

Such was the day-to-day business of the medieval traveler; Battuta and his companions hung the heads of the thirteen unlucky bandits on the walls of the next government fort along their route.[34] He also encountered (as had the Polos) suttee:

> The woman adorns herself, and is accompanied by a cavalcade of the infidel Hindus and Brahmins, with drums, trumpets, and men following her, both Muslims and Infidels for mere pastime. The fire had already been kindled, and into it they threw the dead husband. The wife then threw herself upon him, and both were entirely burnt. A woman's burning herself, however, is not considered absolutely necessary among them…. But when she does not burn herself, she is ever after clothed coarsely, and remains in constraint among her relatives, on account of her want of fidelity to her husband.[35]

Battuta finally arrived in Delhi, where he encountered what was surely one of the most curious credit markets in the history of finance. The favor of Muhammad Tughluq, on which much enterprise (and certainly the fortunes of a foreign *qadi* such as Battuta) rested, had to be bought with

lavish gifts. These gifts, in turn, were rewarded with favors from Tughluq of far greater value, creating a further sense of financial obligation to the court. Since such expensive presents went well beyond the means of the average person, enterprising supplicants almost always had to borrow:

> The merchants of China and India began to furnish each newcomer with thousands of dinars as a loan, and to supply him with whatever he might desire to offer as a gift.… They place both their money and their persons at his service, and stand before him like attendants. When he reaches the sultan, he receives a magnificent gift from him and pays off his debt to them. This trade of theirs is a flourishing one and brings in vast profits.[36]

Even if the supplicant was successful, the lavish lifestyle of the court usually swept him into a downward credit spiral. Although Battuta eventually found himself *qadi* of Delhi, in charge of a royal mausoleum, and the tax farmer of several villages, he still accumulated a debt of 55,000 silver dinars (roughly 4,000 gold dinars).

Battuta had mounted not only a financial tiger in Delhi, but a political one as well. Even for his time, Tughluq was a particularly bloodthirsty master. His interest in Islamic law imparted to him the menace of the ideologically pure, so familiar to the modern world. Disloyalty, real or imagined, hastened the end of many of his subjects, and a lack of doctrinal purity was also a reliable shortcut to the next world. As one modern scholar put it:

> It was one thing to chastise rebels by having them cut in half, skinned alive, or tossed about with elephants with swords attached to their tusks (the latter of which Battuta was to witness more than once). It was quite another thing to inflict such humiliations on distinguished scholars and holy men for merely questioning public policy.[37]

A brief association with a dissident Sufi cleric earned Battuta nine days under armed guard, during which he imagined one unpleasant end after another. Disillusioned with his terms of employment, he pleaded with the sultan to allow him to depart on the hajj; instead, he was made an offer he couldn’t refuse: the ambassadorship to Kublai Khan’s China. Preferring escape east with a retinue of ambassadorial slaves, concubines, and an escort of one thousand horsemen to escape west as a pilgrim, he left for China.

Even in the best of times, danger plagued the overland journey from Delhi to the Malabar Coast, from where his enormous party would embark for China. And with Tughluq’s regime tottering, these were not the best of

times. A few days out of New Delhi, a force of four thousand rebels attacked his entourage. Although they greatly outnumbered the ambassador's party, the attackers were slaughtered, apparently at little cost. Shortly thereafter, another rebel force captured Battuta, who escaped just before he was to be executed.

He rejoined his party and embarked from the northwestern Indian port of Cambay in four relatively small Indian craft for the southwestern port of Calicut. (Calicut is on the other side of the subcontinent from Calcutta, which would be settled two centuries later by the British.) This was pepper country, and the farther south he went, the richer the towns became. As the land grew more fertile and prosperous, the more frequent became his sightings of the huge Chinese junks sent to fetch the mountains of black spice used by Kublai's subjects to flavor their dishes. Fifty years before, Marco Polo had observed of Zaitun's spice markets, "The quantity of pepper imported there is so great that what is carried to Alexandria to supply the demand of the western parts of the world is trifling in comparison—perhaps not more than a hundredth part."[38]

Ibn Battuta cared little for such details of maritime technology or the volume of trade between India and China (or, for that matter, almost everything else besides Islamic law and the finer things in life). He was, however, smitten by the luxurious Chinese vessels, with their multiple decks, private enclosed toilets, steward service, lifeboats, and, of course, a cabin door "which can be bolted by the occupant, who may take with him his female slaves and women."[39]

To Battuta's annoyance, Chinese officials had already reserved the best rooms in the huge ships, leaving him with a smaller cabin, sans private bathroom. This simply would not do, so he took a larger room on a smaller Indian vessel. While he was at Friday prayers, the flotilla of large junks and smaller Indian ships put to sea to ride out a sudden storm; the junks went aground and sank, while the smaller vessel he was supposed to be on, carrying his servants, luggage, and concubines (one of whom was pregnant with his child), sailed south without him, and later was captured in Sumatra by "heathen" (i.e., Hindus).

Battuta eventually found passage to China on yet a smaller boat and in greatly reduced company. Along the way, on the western Malay Peninsula, he was the guest of a king and witnessed a strange spectacle. One of the

ruler's subjects, wishing to demonstrate his loyalty, held a knife to his own neck:

> He then made a long speech, not a word of which I could understand; he then firmly grasped the knife, and its sharpness and the force with which he urged it were such that he severed his head from his body, and it fell to the ground…. The King said to me: Does any among you do such a thing? I answered, I never saw one do so. He smiled and said: "These our servants do so, out of their love to us."[40]

Shortly thereafter, Battuta spent several months in the northern Sumatran city of Samudera, awaiting the reversal of the monsoons that would blow him north to China. At the time of his visit there, it was the first place in Southeast Asia to come under Islamic rule, spread by Muslim traders from India. The year was 1345, and Battuta had no way of knowing that he was witnessing the vanguard of a religious conversion that would produce the modern world's most populous Muslim nation, Indonesia.

Battuta's travelogue grows increasingly sketchy as he arrives in China. He recounts extensive travel there, supposedly covering thousands of miles of roads and canals between Beijing and Canton in a few months, an impossibly short period of time. He was not pleased with what he saw. As he so often does in *Travels*, Battuta affects the mood of a surly Western package tourist who consorts only with his own countrymen and is fed strange food, housed in substandard hotels, and cheated at every turn by the locals:

> I was greatly troubled thinking about the way paganism dominated this country. Whenever I went out of my lodging, I saw many blameworthy things. That disturbed me so much that I stayed indoors most of the time and went out only when necessary.[41]

Neither was Battuta pleased with the remarkable Chinese innovation of paper currency. Like the archetypal American abroad exasperated with foreign "funny money," he complained: "When any one goes to the market with a dinar or a dirhem in his hand, no one will take it until it has been changed for these notes."[42] (Polo, by contrast, thrived on China's religious and cultural diversity: "The country is delightful. The people are idolators."[43])

Not everything Battuta saw in China displeased him. Like Marco Polo, he marveled at the size of Zaitun, which by then was a city with six separate boroughs: one for ordinary Chinese, one for the city's guards, one for the

Jews and Christians, one for sailors and fishermen, one for the seat of government, and, of course, one for Muslims. This metropolis, probably the world's largest at the time, took three full days to circumnavigate. He also could not help commenting favorably on the safety of travel within China, an unimaginable luxury to someone inured to the perils of the road in Asia and the Middle East. His most enthusiastic entry, naturally enough, came when he encountered in the port city of Fuzhou a fellow Moroccan from near his home in Tangier, who gave Battuta many wonderful gifts, among which were two white male slaves, and in addition, two local females.[44]

In many regards, the Genoese Polo and the Moroccan Battuta provided mirror images of the epic medieval wanderer: Polo was Christian, intensely curious about the peoples, customs, and places he visited, and almost completely dependent on the goodwill of the Mongol khans of China and central Asia. By contrast, Battuta was Muslim, profoundly uncurious about the non-Islamic world, and achieved his greatest degree of wealth, fame, and influence in the Muslim court of Delhi.

The Polos eagerly sought contact with the non-Christians of Asia, if for no other reason than simply to survive and conduct business. Polo's fascination with and openness to outside influences shines through every page of his memoirs; the same cannot be said of Battuta, who exudes a remarkable lack of interest in non-Muslim peoples and affairs. About all that ties the two accounts together is that they concerned the East and were transcribed by a professional writer.

It is precisely Battuta's lack of interest in peoples outside *Dar-al-Islam*—the world of Islam—that testifies to Muslim dominance of medieval Asian trade. In the fourteenth century, Battuta could travel 74,000 miles through Morocco, East Africa, India, central Asia, Southeast Asia, and China and remain entirely within the Muslim cultural envelope, never having to interact in a meaningful manner with those outside it in order to survive, to travel, or even to make a living.

The Muslim spice importer in Cairo or Tangier obeyed the same religious, ethical, and—most important—commercial code (and was just as likely to need the services of a *qadi* like Battuta) as his Muslim supplier in Cambay or Malacca. The Muslim ruler, whether in Africa, Arabia, India, or Southeast Asia, observed the same basic rules regarding tax and customs rates. Typically, 2.5 percent was charged to believers, 5 percent to protected

dhimmi (Christians and Jews), and 10 percent to nonprotected nonbelievers, such as Hindus and animist natives.[45]

The hajj, the Muslim obligation to visit Mecca and Medina, served to unite the world of Indian Ocean trade. Not all could afford the hajj, and many, if not most, who did undertake the expensive voyage paid for it with baggage of spices, silks, and cottons, in the process making the port city of Jeddah one of the era's great commercial centers.[46]

Certainly, the Indian Ocean, studded with more or less autonomous trading states, was no Muslim lake. The rulers of these states belonged to different nationalities and sects, and some were not even Muslim. Calicut, for instance, was ruled by the Hindu *zamorin.* Nonetheless, it is no exaggeration to state that the world of fourteenth-century medieval Indian Ocean trade was essentially one and the same with *Dar-al-Islam.*

In Battuta's obsession with *sharia* and the Muslim world and in his lack of interest in nearly everything outside it (besides the comforts of Chinese junks) we clearly see the double-edged sword of Islam so visible in today's world: an ecumenical but self-satisfied faith capable of uniting far-flung peoples under one system of belief and one regime of law, but also severely limited in its capacity to examine and borrow from others.

The Chinese leviathans of the Indian Ocean so admired by Battuta were the technological wonders of the medieval age. Beginning around the eleventh century, the Song Dynasty, forced to the south coast of China by steppe nomads, shifted their strategic focus toward the sea. In 1132, the emperor established a permanent navy, a nearly unheard-of innovation in the East. The Chinese military leadership made maritime engineering a high priority, and their boatyards began to turn out many types of huge military and maritime vessels with iron-nailed, multiple nested hulls; several decks; highly effective stern-mounted rudders; magnetic compass guidance (which allowed accurate navigation even in cloudy weather); and advanced fore-and-aft sails (which enabled ships to tack almost directly into the wind). The Chinese even briefly abandoned their famous cultural chauvinism and borrowed the sophisticated navigational techniques of the Persians and Indians.[47]

Compared with these advanced Chinese craft, the traditional Indian Ocean dhow, with its single hull stitched with coconut fiber, its clumsy lateen rigging (which had to be hauled up and down with each change of tack), and its lack of decks, was so flimsy that Marco Polo chose to endure the rigors, expense, and dangers of the Silk Road rather than embark on one at Hormuz.

One Westerner noted that the dhows were

> mighty frail and uncouth with no iron in them and no caulking. They are sewn like clothes with twine! And so if the twine breaks anywhere there is a breach indeed! Once every year, therefore, there is a mending of this, more or less, if they propose to go to sea. They have a flimsy rudder like the top of a table … and when they have to tack, it is done with a great deal of trouble; and if it is blowing in any hard way, they cannot tack at all.[48]

Another European observed that the Chinese junks tended to

> be very big, and have upon the ship's hull more than 100 cabins, and with a fair wind they carry ten sails, and they are very bulky, being made of three thicknesses of plank, so that the first thickness is as great as in our ships, the second cross-wise, and the third again long-wise. In sooth 'tis a very strong affair.[49]

Nautical historians have in fact wondered why the Indians and Arabs stuck with the dhow so long, almost to the present day, and did not adopt the superior Chinese and European designs. The answer is at least threefold. First, the weight of tradition among Indian shipbuilders overwhelmed the needs of sailors for secure oceangoing craft. Second, India's west coast did not produce enough iron for construction. Third, although the sewn craft may have been less seaworthy, they were more "beachworthy"—that is, more pliable, and thus better able to survive the frequent encounters with the reefs, rocks, and shallows of the coasting trade than were the more rigid planked and ribbed Chinese and European ships.[50]

Given China's advantage in maritime technology, the relatively low profile of its traders west of Malacca is remarkable. Only during the period between 1405 and 1433 did the Chinese intentionally flex their muscle in the Indian Ocean. Perhaps the inferior status accorded traders by Confucianism, which viewed merchants as parasites, steered the brightest and most ambitious away from trade and into the economically stifling Mandarin bureaucracy. Then too, China's (and later, Japan's) centralized political structure could quickly shut off contact with the outside world.

In contrast, the highly decentralized nature of the medieval world of Indian Ocean trade produced a bubbling stew of Darwinian economic competition, in which those states whose political "mutations" were best suited to trade and commerce thrived, and those whose institutions were not withered. In much the same way, the political environment of Europe, fractured by its mountainous and riverine geography into thousands of competing states, favored those nations with the most economically efficient institutions. One of them, England, would emerge as history's first truly global hegemon.[51]

In 1382, the army of the first Ming emperor, Zhu Yuanzhang, which had been pursuing the remnants of the Mongol army, captured a ten-year-old Muslim peasant boy named Ma. The commanding general asked the young captive the whereabouts of the Mongol pretender and received this impertinent answer: "He jumped into a pond." Ma's insouciance earned him captivity in the royal household, and three years later, as was the custom, he was castrated and added to the eunuch staff of the royal household, in this case of Zhu Di, the fourth of the emperor's twenty-six sons.

Unlike most eunuchs, he did not develop a shrill tongue or a feminine manner, but instead grew into a huge, fierce, intelligent warrior with a deep booming voice. When his master, Zhu Di, finally became emperor after a brutal civil war against his older brother, the young protégé was promoted to the powerful position of superintendent of the office of eunuchs.[52] His new name was Zheng He, or, as he was until recently called in the West, Cheng Ho, the commander of the treasure fleet and master of the Indian Ocean.

History associates the voyages of the great Chinese treasure fleets—seven in all between 1405 and 1433—with Zheng He, but these spectacular missions were for all intents and purposes just one cog in the grand design of the expansionist Emperor Zhu Di, and, in the end, a pawn in the age-old antagonism between the Confucian scholars and the eunuchs.

Zhu Di, unlike his isolationist peasant-warrior father, was a cultured ruler with an internationalist worldview who engaged China in dozens of costly foreign adventures. These efforts included diplomatic and military missions to the Mongol former enemy and, less successfully, an invasion of

Vietnam that started a long and brutal guerrilla war (and from which modern France and America failed to learn the appropriate lessons).

None of Zhu Di's many spectacular projects left their mark on history as did the great treasure fleets, the gargantuan successors to the vessels so coveted by Ibn Battuta. These ships ranged in size from relatively small support boats "only" a hundred feet in length to the massive three-to four-hundred-foot-long "treasure ships," with their multiple nail-bound, watertight hull compartments; up to nine masts; dozens of spacious cabins; and sophisticated stern-post rudders of a type that would not be seen in Europe until the early modern period.[53]

Most voyages consisted of about three hundred vessels manned by approximately thirty thousand crew members, and sailed on two-year expeditions to Malacca, Sumatra, Java, and India, and on later journeys to Hormuz, the Red Sea, and much of the East African coast. The treasure fleets were hardly opening new markets for Chinese commerce; we know from Polo, Battuta, and Chinese and Muslim observers that they had been preceded into Asian ports by previous generations of Chinese diplomats and merchants. Rather, the primary purposes of the seven successive missions were diplomatic, military, and symbolic.

The monsoons drove the carefully choreographed arc of each voyage. Zheng He's fleets assembled in the fall at an anchorage at Taiping in southern China, where they waited for the winter northeast monsoon to carry them to Surabaya in Java. There they remained until July, when the southwest monsoon blew them past Sumatra and Malacca to Sri Lanka and the Malabar Coast of India. Smaller detachments then ranged as far as Hormuz and Africa. Over the next twelve months, the process was reversed: south to Java with the winter northeast monsoon, then homeward on the summer southwest monsoon.

First and foremost, the ventures stabilized the critical Strait of Malacca, ruled by a renegade Sumatran sultan but claimed by the Siamese, who controlled Chinese access to the Indian Ocean. Zheng He not only suppressed the piracy that was rampant in the strait, but also adroitly reconciled competing Siamese and Malaccan interests in the vital waterway, keeping it open to the commerce of all parties. An additional, unspoken charge of Zheng He may have been to search for Zhu Yunwen, the brother Zhu Di supplanted, who was reported to have fled overseas.[54]

Much of what is known about the treasure fleets comes from the memoirs of a Chinese Muslim translator, Ma Huan, who was fluent in Arabic. He accompanied Zheng He's later voyages, and his description of the visit to the sultan of Malacca speaks eloquently to the nature of "treasure fleet diplomacy":

> [The emperor bestowed upon the sultan] two silver seals, a hat, a girdle, and a robe. [Zheng He] set up a stone tablet and raised [Malacca] to a city, and it was subsequently called the country of Malacca. Thereafter [the king of Siam] did not dare to invade it. The sultan, having received the favor of having been made a king, conducted his wife and son and went to the court [in China] to return thanks and present tribute of local products. The court also granted him a sea-going ship, so that he might return to his country and protect his land.[55]

In India and Arabia, Ma Huan encountered the wellsprings of Western monotheism. In Calicut he recorded this wonderful whispering-down-the-lane story of Exodus, concerning one

> Mou-hsieh, who established a religious cult; the people knew that he was a true man of Heaven, and all men revered and followed him. Later the holy man went away to another with [others] to another place, and ordered his younger brother to govern and teach the people.

Unfortunately, this younger brother taught the people to worship a golden ox, saying, "It always excretes gold. The people got the gold, and their hearts rejoiced; and they forgot the way of Heaven; all took the ox to be the true lord." The prophet Mou-hsieh returns, destroys the ox, and banishes his brother, who "mounted a large elephant and vanished."[56]

Whatever his diplomatic and cross-cultural accomplishments, Zheng He earned little economic reward for an effort that consumed most of the nation's timber, shipbuilding capacity, and much of its military force. The most famous and prized of the fleets' cargoes produced only evanescent symbolic value: several African giraffes obtained from Arabian and Indian rulers as tribute. The beasts were valued not only because of their exotic and pleasing appearance, but also because they were thought by the Chinese to be an animal known as the *qilin.* This mythical beast had a unicorn's horn, horse's hooves, wolf's forehead, ox's tail, and musk deer's body, and was said to appear only at times of peace and prosperity. Another tribute gift from Malacca that captivated the Chinese were strange clear glass objects which magnified the size of tiny written characters —almost certainly the first eyeglasses, which had recently been invented in Venice.[57]

Worse, much of both the fleets' cargoes—outbound, porcelain and silk; and inbound, spices, precious stones, woolens, and carpets—passed through the warehouses of Zheng He's fellow eunuchs, who controlled most of the nation's overseas commerce. On the death of Zhu Di in 1424, the eunuchs and the xenophobic Confucian bureaucracy faced off in a power struggle. The Confucians' victory ended the great age of Chinese exploration. Zheng He died in command of the seventh voyage; after it returned up the Yangtze River in July 1433, none would follow.

Within a few generations, the Chinese allowed their naval and merchant fleets to wither; in 1500, an imperial edict made the construction of vessels with more than two masts a capital offense. In 1525, another decree forbade the building of *any* oceangoing vessel. Where navies are absent, pirates pillage. By the middle of the sixteenth century, Japanese *wako* marauders so terrorized China's coastline that to this day women in Fujian province hide their faces with blue scarves originally designed to shield the wearer from the lecherous gaze of foreign bandits.[58]

Recently, Zheng He's voyages have become a subject of revisionist history. In *1421: The Year China Discovered America*, the retired English submarine commander Gavin Menzies suggested that a detachment from Zheng He's sixth expedition visited America (as well as Australia, New Zealand, the Atlantic coast of Brazil, and the Cape Verde Islands); his claims, for the most part, are not taken seriously by maritime historians.[59]

Today, as China begins to flex its newfound military and economic power, it uses Zheng He's voyages to illustrate to the outside world the historically benign and nonaggressive nature of Chinese foreign policy. It would do better not to draw too much attention to the details of the missions, which on many occasions kidnapped and slaughtered those who did not pay proper homage to imperial authority. For example, on his first expedition, Zheng He killed over five thousand pirates in the Strait of Malacca; their leader was returned to China, presented to the emperor, and decapitated. On later voyages, Zheng He captured and carried back the rulers of Sri Lanka, Palembang in eastern Sumatra, and Semudera (near modern Banda Aceh), and on numerous occasions led his troops into battle.[60]

Da Gama and Zheng He missed each other by just sixty-five years; it can only be imagined what might have occurred had the first Europeans to visit

the Indian Ocean encountered the treasure fleet, whose smallest support junks would have towered over the puny Portuguese caravels. Fortunately for the Portuguese, the fickle mistress of history spared them this humiliation. When Vasco da Gama breached the Indian Ocean, the playing field had just been vacated by the one force capable of repelling him.

On April 20, 1511, Tomé Pires, an apothecary (and thus knowledgeable about rare spices), shipped out from Lisbon to seek his fortune in India. He never returned to his mother country, for he was sent as the first official European ambassador to the Celestial Empire, where he died in captivity at age seventy. His story might have remained unknown had not a Portuguese researcher visiting the French National Library in the 1930s come across the "Paris Codex." This volume contained, among other documents, Pires's *Suma Oriental*, an account of his travels. He described the Indian Ocean emporium trade just before it disappeared under the boots of the Europeans, and he affords us a detailed and intimate last look at the indigenous world of Asian commerce.

At that time, the primary axis of Asian trade ran from the massive Gujarati port at Cambay (about sixty miles south of the modern western Indian metropolis of Ahmadabad), the marshalling point for Indian textiles and European goods moving east toward Malacca. There, they would be traded for rare spices and Chinese silks and porcelains.

Pires described the broad estuary of the Mahi River, on which Cambay sits, as stretching out "two arms; with her right arm she reaches out towards Aden, and with the other towards Malacca."[61] Although Cambay was ruled by Muslim Mughals, the city's long-distance commerce was dominated by its Hindu trading castes:

> There is no doubt that these people have the cream of the trade. They are men who understand merchandise; they are so properly steeped in the sound and harmony of it, that the Gujaratis say that any offense connected with merchandise is pardonable. There are Gujaratis settled everywhere…. They are diligent, quick men in trade. They do their accounts with figures like ours and with our very writing.… There are also Cairo merchants settled in Cambay, and many Khorasans and Guilans from Aden and Hormuz, all of whom do a great trade in the seaport towns of Cambay…. Those of our people who want to be clerks and factors ought to go there and learn, because the business of trade is a science in itself which does not hinder any other noble exercise, but helps a great deal.[62]

The Portuguese of the sixteenth century were perhaps the most outrageously chauvinistic of the Western intruders in Asia and the Americas. Pires's observation that his countrymen had much to learn from the heathen Gujaratis thus spoke volumes about the scope and sophistication of the indigenous Asian trade.

Pires worked no more than nine months in India before Portugal's master of the East, Afonso de Albuquerque, dispatched him to Malacca, which had just fallen to the Portuguese. At the time of his arrival there, Malacca was a relatively new city, whose indigenous origins predated by little more than a century its conquest by the Portuguese. Sometime around 1400, a Hindu sultan, Parameswara, the local ruler of the Sumatran city of Palembang (which lies about halfway between modern Singapore and Java) defied the Hindu Majapahit ruler of Java and was forced to flee north toward Singapore and the strait. After first conquering Singapore, Parameswara then settled in Malacca, which derives its name from an old Malay word, *malaqa*, meaning "hidden fugitive."[63]

The Hindu Majapahits, under attack from Muslim enclaves in Java and Sumatra and riven internally by strife and corruption, were on the way out. Parameswara proved the right man in the right place at the right time: canny, attuned to commerce, and possessed of innumerable contacts among both local and foreign traders in Palembang and beyond. Further, he was now in control of a fine natural port just out of range of the strife in Java and southern Sumatra, but still commanding the strait. That Parameswara concentrated his efforts on commerce through the strait was no accident—he was one of the last in a line of princes of the seafaring empire of Crivijaya. From its capital in Palembang, this empire had at one point ruled over large parts of Sumatra, Java, and the Malay Peninsula. Its wealth and power derived from its control of the local and longdistance trade through the strait.

Parameswara's heirs proved just as talented, and Malacca soon became one of the world's commercial fulcrums. What Singapore is to the modern world—a sprawling entrepôt commanding one of the world's key maritime choke points—Malacca, which lies 130 miles northwest of modern Singapore, was to the Middle Ages. Just as Singapore does today, medieval Malacca connected India, the Arab world, and Europe to its west with China and the legendary Spice Islands to its east.

Malacca dazzled Pires, and the city's sights, smells, and activity evoked in him a vision of the promised land. A meticulous observer, Pires possessed both a ready facility with numbers—rare among colonial officials of that era—and an eye for the fine points of government and trade. Although *Suma Oriental* is no one's idea of beach reading, the magic of Malacca at the very moment the Portuguese conquered it shines through. Pires counted eighty-four tongues being spoken, in a city as multicultural as London or New York, by the likes of:

> Moors from Cairo, Mecca, Aden, Abyssinians, men of Kilwa, Malindi, Hormuz, Parsees, Rumes, Turks, Turkomens, Christian Armenians, Gujaratis, men of Chaul, Dabhol, Goa, of the Kingdom of Deccan, Malabars and Klings, merchants from Orissa, Ceylon, Bengal, Arakan, Pegu, Siamese, men of Kedah, Malays, men of Pahang, Patani, Cambodia, Champa, Cochin China, Chinese, Lequeos, men of Brunei, Luçoes, men of Tamjompura, Laue, Banka, Linga (they have a thousand other islands), Moluccas, Banda, Bima, Timor, Madura, Java, Sunda, Palembang, Jambi, Tongkal, Indragiri, Kappatta, Menangkabau, Siak, Arcat, Aru, Bata, country of the Tomjano, Pase, Pedir, Maldives.[64]

As pointed out by the historian and sociologist Janet Abu-Lughod, "No single other fact can quite capture the 'shape' of the world system by the fifteenth century as this cast of characters."[65] The presence of "Rumes" is especially intriguing, as this term was variously applied to southern Europeans, Turks, or Byzantine Greeks (Constantinople having been conquered sixty years previously by the Turks). Were there Italians already in Malacca before the Portuguese arrived? By 1326, following the enthusiastic reports of Marco Polo, Genoese merchants were a common sight in Zaitun, China's greatest port, so it would not have been surprising if Pires had found them in Malacca as well. The Genoese were at least as well traveled as the Venetians, but also famously close-mouthed about the particulars of their fabulously profitable trade routes. It is no accident that the first detailed reports of the Far East came from more voluble Venetians such as Marco Polo.[66] Even if there were no Italians in Malacca, their signature merchandise, transshipped from Alexandria and brought by Indian traders via the Red Sea and Cambay, abounded there: scarlet dye, colored woolens, beads, glass, and weapons of every type.

The massive flow of goods into the port was overseen by four harbormasters, one each for cargoes from the Arab Middle East and India, from Siam and China, from the local Sumatran ports, and from the rest of Indonesia. Pires observed that the main axis of trade was between Gujarat

in western India, particularly its main port of Cambay, and Malacca. The most prized of Indian commodities was cloth, of which he documented thirty types, as well as opium and incense from farther west. More varied goods—mace, nutmeg, cloves, sandalwood, and tin, as well as Chinese silk and porcelain—flowed west, some bound for India, some for the Gulf, and some for Egypt and Europe. Pires mentions that four ships per year came from the smaller ports of Gujarat, each carrying a cargo worth up to thirty thousand cruzados (about $2.4 million in today's money), whereas just one giant annual shipment came from Cambay, valued at about "sev enty or eighty thousand cruzados, without any doubt."[67] And all this from just the western coast of India; vessels to and from India's east coast likely carried a similar amount of goods as well.

What went right at Malacca? Its prosperity did not flow simply from its favorable location at one of the maritime world's critical choke points, "at the end of the monsoons."[68] After all, the strait stretches several hundred miles along the Malay and Sumatran coasts and is far easier to control at its narrower Singapore end. Further, both the Malay side and the Sumatran side were studded with trading cities for centuries before Parameswara founded Malacca in 1400.

Rather, the city's wealth and prominence can be credited to the institutional genius of Parameswara and his heirs. Alone among the many trading cities that lined the strait, Malacca had found the answer to the question of whether to trade, raid, or protect. The Malaccans levied import duties less onerous than those prescribed by traditional Islamic custom, the maximum being just 6 percent (instead of the usual 10 percent), payable on imports from "the West"—that is, those brought by Indians and Arabs. If a Westerner and his wife were both settled in the port, they paid only 3 percent. Easterners —local Malays, Indonesians (including the Moluccans with their precious spices), Siamese, and Chinese—paid no formal import duties at all. From all imports, even from "Easterners," were subtracted "presents" to the sultan and his lieutenants, estimated by Pires at a cost of 1 or 2 percent of cargo value. No trader, Eastern, Western, or local, paid an export duty.

A reasonably solid, if informal, legal structure seems to have been in place, rivaling even the advanced common law of medieval England. The sultan's chief civil officer, called the *bendara*, was a sort of mayor cum

chief justice, who oversaw disputes and ensured that business ran smoothly. (He was also one of the recipients of the aforementioned "presents.") A brother of the *bendara* was usually appointed *tumungam*, or customs judge, who together with a panel of local and foreign traders valued the cargo; duties were then collected and the cargo was thrown open to bids from a yet larger group of merchants:

> And because time was short and the merchandise considerable, the merchants were cleared [i.e., the cargo fully sold], and then those of Malacca took the merchandise to their ships and sold them at their pleasure; from which the traders received their settlement and gains,and the local merchants made their profits…. And that it was thus done orderly, so that they did not favor the merchant from the ship, nor did he go away displeased; *for the law and the prices of merchandise in Malacca are well known.* (italics added)[69]

Adam Smith would surely have approved, for here, in fewer than a hundred short words, is the essential recipe for free-market success: an auction process conducted with well-described and well-known rules at a single point in time by a large number of well-informed participants, backed by government institutions considered honest by the participants—a sort of medieval eBay in the tropics, in which good rules attracted good traders, who in turn insisted on even better rules.

Neither did it hurt that Parameswara, in order to fend off the Majapahits of Java, converted to Islam so that he might marry the daughter of the Muslim king of Pase (in northern Sumatra) and thus acquire the king's badly needed protection against the Hindu enemy. By 1400, the majority of the merchants in the strait were disciples of the Prophet, even if the local population was not. That Muslim commerce proceeded ahead of conversion in Southeast Asia was no accident; whereas theology is the primary driving force behind Christianity and the great Eastern religions, Islam's backbone is a system of law covering all areas of conduct, including commerce. Thus, the new monotheism from Arabia was especially attractive to those engaged in any organized economic activity that flourished wherever rules were plainly visible and vigorously enforced by disinterested parties—again, as in the more secular English common law.

Even if one was not moved by religious fervor, embracing Islam at least did wonders for one's credit rating. Only later would the general population, impressed with the wealth and piety of their Muslim merchant neighbors, follow their path.[70] The conversion of much of Southeast Asia was accomplished not by conquerors roaring out of Arabia and Persia, but rather

by cloth and spice merchants from Cambay and Calicut, who often married native women. Their mixed-race offspring, regardless of their mother's religion, were almost always raised as Muslims and served to spread the word of the Prophet among their peers and their mothers' friends and families.[71] (When Pires arrived in Malacca, Muslim traders were still actively spreading the word of Muhammad across the Hindu empires of Java, Sumatra, and eastern Indonesia, even as the West was reclaiming Islam's western domains in Spain and southeastern Europe.)

Like the previous Crivijaya, Parameswara kept open his lines of communication to China, which included Zheng He's fleets. The sultan and the Chinese cultivated each other, partly to keep the Siamese, who were rivals of both the Malaccans and the Chinese, at bay; between 1411 and 1419, Parameswara is thought to have visited China and paid tribute to Zhu Di on many occasions. By the time the Chinese left the Indian Ocean in 1433, the Malaccans were more than capable of filling the vacuum in the strait.

Malacca was certainly not the only Indian Ocean principality to hit on the essential formula for a prosperous coastal trading state—Pires's memoirs simply highlight the virtues of one of the most successful. The cities and ports between Venice and Canton that blossomed during the Middle Ages must have followed more or less the same precepts. In Calicut a series of hereditary Hindu rulers, the *zamorin*, maintained the legal, commercial, and maritime military institutions necessary for commercial success. Unfortunately for Calicut, it would be da Gama's first stop in India.

Alas, as Britons today will attest, even the most vigorous royal lines eventually peter out. Unluckily for Malacca, just as the Portuguese were appearing on the horizon, its leadership fell into the hands of a dissolute sultan, Mahmud Shah, from whom the Europeans plucked the city like a plump avocado. The rules of the game would soon change for the Muslims and other Asians engaged in the ancient trade of the Indian Ocean, and not for the better. In one of history's most bizarre chains of causation, the brutal, efficient newcomers were driven by a hunger for, of all things, culinary ingredients that today lie largely unused in most Western kitchens.